



2026 EDITION

Annapolis Boat Shows Do's & Don'ts

Your Essential Guide to All Four 2026 Shows
Navigate Like a Seasoned Pro

Bay Bridge Boat Show

April 17–19, 2026
Safe Harbor Narrows Point

Spring Sailboat Show

April 24–26, 2026
City Dock, Annapolis

US Powerboat Show

October 8–11, 2026
City Dock, Annapolis

US Sailboat Show

October 15–18, 2026
City Dock, Annapolis

FREE GUIDE

Expert Advice from 25+ Years on the Chesapeake Bay

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2026 Show Dates, Tickets & Key Info

Annapolis Boat Shows hosts four premier in-water events in 2026. Here is everything you need to know before you go.

Bay Bridge Boat Show

April 17–19, 2026

Safe Harbor Narrows Point
Kent Island, MD

Spring Sailboat Show

April 24–26, 2026

Fri 10AM–6PM | Sat 10AM–6PM | Sun
10AM–5PM

City Dock, Annapolis, MD

US Powerboat Show

October 8–11, 2026

Preview Day: October 2

City Dock / Ego Alley, Annapolis, MD

US Sailboat Show

October 15–18, 2026

City Dock / Ego Alley, Annapolis, MD

2026 Ticket Prices (Powerboat & Sailboat Shows)

General Admission	\$32
Preview Day (Oct 2 - Powerboat)	\$45
Children Ages 7–15	\$10
Children 6 & Under	FREE
Military Personnel Day (Sun Oct 11 only)	\$22
Box Office Location	Dock St. / Exit Bus at 2nd Stop

 **2026 Parking Alert:** City Dock construction on lower Dock Street will alter show setup. Use city garages: Hillman, Knighton, Gotts Court, or Park Place. Take the FREE Downtown "Magenta" Shuttle along West and Main Streets. Calvert Street Garage (19 St. Johns St.) is free after 6PM weekdays and all weekend.

 **What Makes Annapolis Unique:** For over 50 years, Annapolis has hosted the world's premier in-water boat shows. Every boat you board is floating in the historic Chesapeake Bay. You're not just shopping — you're standing in the "Sailing Capital of the United States."





Introduction: Why This Guide Matters

Welcome, fellow Chesapeake Bay boating enthusiast!

The 2026 Annapolis Boat Shows are here — four world-class in-water events that draw tens of thousands of boaters to the docks of historic City Dock. Whether it's April's Spring Sailboat Show or October's flagship Powerboat and Sailboat Shows, each event offers incredible opportunity — and real risk if you're not prepared.

I've attended the Annapolis shows for over 25 years — as an exhibitor, as a buyer, and as a Chesapeake Bay maritime professional. I've seen smart buyers save \$10,000+ and watched unprepared attendees make \$5,000 mistakes before lunch.

This guide will help you:

- **Save thousands** by knowing when and how to negotiate at each show
- **Navigate Annapolis specifically** — parking, crowds, City Dock layout
- **Choose the right show** for what you're shopping for
- **Make the most of all four 2026 events**
- **Make informed decisions** instead of impulse purchases

Which 2026 Show Is Right for You?

Show	Best For	Crowd Level
Bay Bridge (Apr 17–19)	Power & sail, relaxed atmosphere	Low–Medium
Spring Sailboat (Apr 24–26)	Sailors, brokerage boats, spring deals	Medium
US Powerboat (Oct 8–11)	Motor yachts, trawlers, fishing boats	Very High
US Sailboat (Oct 15–18)	Sailing yachts, charter companies	Very High

💡 **Annapolis Pro Tip:** The October shows draw 60,000+ attendees. If you want real face-time with dealers and the ability to board boats without waiting, the April shows are your secret weapon. Spring prices are also softer — dealers want to move inventory before summer.





Before You Go: Essential Preparation

1 Register Online & Save

Buy tickets at **annapolisboatshows.com** before arrival. Box office is at Dock St. — lines can be 30+ minutes on peak days. Online tickets also unlock early access info and show maps weeks before the event.

2 Plan Your Parking Strategy

This is critical for the Annapolis shows. City Dock construction in 2026 has altered traffic patterns significantly.

- **City Garages:** Hillman, Knighton, Gotts Court, or Park Place
- **Free Shuttle:** "Magenta" shuttle runs West and Main Streets all show days
- **Calvert Street Garage** (19 St. Johns St.): Free after 6PM weekdays, free all weekend
- **Whitmore Garage** (25 Clay St.): Available for a fee after 9AM Mon–Sat; free Sundays until 4PM
- **Residential streets:** Reserved for Ward One residents only — don't risk a ticket

3 Download the Show Floor Plan

The October shows use Ego Alley and Annapolis Harbor — floating docks create a temporary marina. Study the layout at **annapolisboatshows.com** and identify your priority exhibitors before you arrive.

4 Get Your Finances in Order

- Pre-approval for marine financing
- Clear budget including taxes, insurance, slip fees, and Chesapeake Bay-specific costs
- Trade-in value research on your current boat
- Down payment ready if the right boat appears

⚠ Annapolis-Specific Warning: Never rely solely on show financing without reading the fine print. Some "show special" rates include balloon payments or dealer add-ons. Get all numbers in writing before you leave the dock.

5 What to Wear & Bring

- ☐ Non-slip boat shoes — you're boarding live boats on floating docks
- ☐ Light layers — October on the Bay turns cold fast
- ☐ Sunscreen — Annapolis waterfront offers zero shade
- ☐ Waterproof jacket — afternoon showers are common in October
- ☐ Small backpack for brochures and gear
- ☐ Phone fully charged + portable charger
- ☐ Business cards for dealer follow-ups
- ☐ Measuring tape for berths, storage, cockpit





The Do's: What You Should Absolutely Do

- ✓ **DO arrive at opening time on weekdays.** The October shows are massive — early arrival means shorter lines boarding boats, more attentive salespeople, and first pick of seminar seating.
- ✓ **DO take the Magenta Shuttle.** Driving into City Dock during show hours is a nightmare. Park in a city garage and take the free shuttle — you'll save 45 minutes and serious frustration.
- ✓ **DO board every boat that interests you.** The Annapolis shows are fully in-water. Every boat floats. This is your chance to feel how a boat moves, sits in the water, and lives aboard — something no showroom can replicate.
- ✓ **DO wear proper boat shoes.** The floating docks can be slippery, especially after morning dew or afternoon rain. Non-slip soles are not optional.
- ✓ **DO attend the Schooner Woodwind sails.** During the Sailboat Show, the historic Schooner Woodwind offers 1.5-hour sails right from the show docks. There's no better way to clear your head between booths.
- ✓ **DO visit both October shows.** The Powerboat Show (Oct 8–11) and Sailboat Show (Oct 15–18) are back-to-back but separate tickets. If you're comparing sail vs. power, attend both.
- ✓ **DO photograph every spec sheet and price sheet.** After 20 boats, your notes blur. Photo evidence is clear and comparable.
- ✓ **DO ask about Chesapeake Bay-specific features.** Shoal draft, bridge clearance, and Bay conditions matter here. Ask how boats perform in Bay chop, not just open ocean.
- ✓ **DO check out the brokerage boats.** Every Annapolis show features quality used boats. A well-maintained 3-year-old Bay boat can be 40% less than new.
- ✓ **DO visit accessory and electronics vendors.** Show prices on chartplotters, VHF radios, and safety gear are heavily discounted. This is where Chesapeake Bay sailors stock up.
- ✓ **DO connect with charter companies.** The Sailboat Show draws charter companies offering bareboat and crewed charters — excellent intel if you're deciding between buying and chartering.
- ✓ **DO get everything promised in writing.** Verbal commitments on the dock vanish after show weekend. If they're not on paper, they don't exist.

 **Annapolis Insider Tip:** The last afternoon of each October show (Sunday after 3PM) delivers the best prices. Dealers don't want to pay to float boats back to their yards. But selection thins fast — come knowing exactly what you want.





The Don'ts: Common Mistakes to Avoid

- ✗ **DON'T drive to City Dock during show hours.** Traffic on Compromise Street and Dock Street becomes gridlocked. You'll spend an hour looking for parking that doesn't exist. Use the garages and shuttle.
- ✗ **DON'T go to the October shows on Saturday afternoon.** Peak crowds hit 10,000+ people on the docks simultaneously. You'll wait 20 minutes to board a popular boat. Go Thursday or Friday morning instead.
- ✗ **DON'T make impulse decisions.** The energy of floating boats in Annapolis Harbor is intoxicating. "Today only" deals are almost never truly today only. Sleep on every major decision.
- ✗ **DON'T skip the April shows.** The Spring Sailboat Show (Apr 24–26) is dramatically less crowded and dealers are hungry to move pre-season inventory. It's the Annapolis show most buyers overlook and insiders exploit.
- ✗ **DON'T ignore the construction changes.** 2026 City Dock construction on lower Dock Street has altered show layout and traffic patterns. Review the updated map at annapolisboatshows.com before you arrive.
- ✗ **DON'T buy a Bay boat without asking about draft.** The Chesapeake Bay has shallow areas — ask about keel draft, propeller clearance, and whether the boat is suited for your home waters.
- ✗ **DON'T forget the total ownership cost.** Annapolis slip fees are among the highest on the East Coast. A beautiful \$80,000 boat at the show might cost you \$6,000/year just to park it.
- ✗ **DON'T neglect to check dealer service distance.** If your dealer is 90 minutes away and your engine fails mid-Bay, you have a problem. Ask about local service options before signing anything.
- ✗ **DON'T skip the sea trial on used boats.** The Bay's conditions will expose problems that calm harbor water won't. Insist on a sea trial before any used boat purchase.
- ✗ **DON'T assume "show special" beats regular pricing.** Some dealers inflate prices before the show. Call your shortlist of dealers before attending to know baseline prices.
- ✗ **DON'T bring young children without a plan.** Floating docks, open water, and massive crowds are a challenging environment for kids. Life jackets are available but the docks are not child-proof.
- ✗ **DON'T sign anything without reading every line.** Show contracts sometimes include mandatory electronics packages, prep charges, and delivery fees that inflate the final price significantly.

⚠ Critical Warning: Never wire money or provide financial account details at a boat show. All legitimate transactions go through established dealership or financing protocols. If anyone requests unusual payment methods on the dock — walk away immediately.





Annapolis Local Tips: Parking, Food & More

P Parking Guide

Garage	Location	Cost
Hillman Garage	Downtown Annapolis	Regular rates
Knighton Garage	Downtown Annapolis	Regular rates
Gotts Court Garage	Downtown Annapolis	Regular rates
Park Place Garage	Downtown Annapolis	Regular rates
Calvert Street Garage	19 St. Johns St.	FREE after 6PM & weekends
Whitmore Garage	25 Clay St.	Fee Mon–Sat; FREE Sun until 4PM

 **Shuttle Tip:** The free "Magenta" shuttle runs along West and Main Streets on all show days. Catch it near your parking garage — it drops you within easy walking distance of City Dock. Don't fight parking at the waterfront.

Where to Eat (Near City Dock)

- **Pusser's Caribbean Grille** — Right on the water, great for a mid-day break
- **McGarvey's Saloon** — Annapolis institution, packed during show week
- **Buddy's Crabs & Ribs** — Classic Chesapeake seafood, worth the wait
- **Café Normandie** — Quieter option on Maryland Ave for serious conversations
- **Chick & Ruth's Delly** — Local landmark for breakfast and lunch



Where to Stay

- **Book far in advance** — October show hotels sell out months ahead
- **Loews Annapolis Hotel** — Closest to City Dock, premium price
- **Westin Annapolis** — 10-minute walk, often better rates
- **Consider Bowie or Glen Burnie** — 20 minutes away, significantly cheaper
- **Live aboard option** — Some marinas rent slips for show week visitors

While You're in Annapolis

- **US Naval Academy** — Free guided tours, stunning waterfront grounds
- **Maryland State House** — Oldest state capitol in continuous use in the US
- **Historic Main Street** — Boutiques, galleries, and nautical shops
- **Eastport neighborhood** — The "maritime republic" across the drawbridge
- **Schooner Woodwind** — Sailboat Show sails available during October show





Your 2026 Annapolis Show Checklist

Print this page and bring it with you to the docks.

Before the Show

- ☐ Registered online at annapolisboatshows.com
- ☐ Downloaded 2026 show floor map
- ☐ Identified priority exhibitors and dock locations
- ☐ Planned parking — selected garage and shuttle route
- ☐ Set clear budget including taxes, insurance, and Annapolis slip fees
- ☐ Pre-approved for marine financing (if needed)
- ☐ Researched trade-in value of current boat
- ☐ Checked weather forecast (annapolisboatshows.com updates)
- ☐ Charged phone and packed portable charger

What to Wear/Bring

- ☐ Non-slip boat shoes (mandatory on floating docks)
- ☐ Light layers + waterproof jacket (October Bay weather)
- ☐ Sunscreen (waterfront has zero shade)
- ☐ Small backpack for brochures
- ☐ Business cards for dealer follow-ups
- ☐ Measuring tape
- ☐ Notebook and pen

At Each Boat You Board

- ☐ Photographed boat from multiple angles including bilge
- ☐ Sat in helm station and checked sight lines
- ☐ Tested all hatches, doors, and storage
- ☐ Inspected bilge condition (clean/dry = good build)
- ☐ Tapped hull (solid thunk = good; hollow = thin layup)
- ☐ Asked about Chesapeake Bay-specific features (draft, bridge clearance)
- ☐ Got "out-the-door" price including delivery to local marina
- ☐ Asked about dealer's service location and Bay-area coverage
- ☐ Got salesperson's business card
- ☐ Photographed all spec sheets and price sheets

Before Making Any Offer

- ☐ Compared at least 3 similar models
- ☐ Called insurance agent for Bay-specific quote
- ☐ Verified slip availability at home marina
- ☐ Researched dealer reputation and service reviews
- ☐ Calculated full annual ownership cost (slip, insurance, maintenance, fuel)
- ☐ Slept on it for at least 24 hours
- ☐ Read all contract terms — every line
- ☐ Confirmed all verbal promises are in writing





See You on the Docks in 2026!

You now have the insider knowledge to navigate all four 2026 Annapolis Boat Shows like a seasoned Chesapeake Bay professional. Use it well.

Remember the Key Principles:

- **Take the shuttle** — never fight City Dock parking
- **Go early on weekdays** for the October shows
- **Don't overlook the April shows** — less crowd, better deals
- **Factor in Annapolis slip fees** before you fall in love with a boat
- **Everything in writing** — no exceptions on the dock
- **Sleep on every major decision** — the Bay will still be there tomorrow

Want More Expert Chesapeake Bay Advice?

The Boat Pro Newsletter delivers weekly insights built for serious Chesapeake Bay boaters:

- 🚤 Honest boat reviews from a 25-year Bay professional
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